Towards a better understanding of organizational buying behavior across cultures: empirical evidence from the Arabian Gulf

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this study is to examine, through the lens of the buying center concept, a theorized link between organizational buying behavior (OBB) and a national culture of collectivism, large power distance, particularism and a wasta practice.

Design/methodology/approach – A qualitative methodology was used to gain better understanding of OBB in an under-researched business environment of the Arabian Gulf. The data come from 41 organizational practitioners who reported on the industrial buying processes in their organizations with reference to the buying center framework.

Findings – The study developed a model of the buying center for the emerging markets governed by socio-political institutions.

Research limitations/implications – The data were obtained only from one culturally specific world region.

Practical implications – To attain efficacious results in culturally distant business environments, industrial marketers should complement home country experience with a thorough understanding of how national cultures affect the dynamics of OBB.

Originality/value – The study updates the conceptualization of the buying center's organizational actors (OAs) for business contexts beyond traditional, mature markets. It reveals the typology of decisional influencers, introduces and defines the role of advisers and clarifies the role of the gatekeeping bureaucracy and differing perceptions thereof by OAs.

Keywords Power distance, Wasta, Collectivism, The Arabian Gulf, Organizational buying behavior, Particularism, The buying center

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

The realities of globalization create pressing challenges for industrial marketing, while the growing role of emerging markets worldwide demands new theorizing in the field of organizational buying behavior (OBB) (Spekman, 2015). In addressing the issue, Sheth (2011) emphasized the need to develop fresh perspectives on OBB because of the unique characteristics of emerging markets. These characteristics distinctively differentiate the emerging markets from mature ones and include market heterogeneity, chronic shortage of resources, unbranded completion, inadequate infrastructure and socio-political governance. The last-mentioned factor denotes an environment in which faith-based political governance, coupled with the power of business groups and the influence of local communities, creates markets that tend to be controlled by socio-political institutions rather than governed by competition (Sheth, 2011). This is descriptive of the Arabian Gulf – a world region of growing international importance and the focus of the present study.

The challenges of globalization notwithstanding, industrial marketers can increase the likelihood of success in emerging markets by gaining a systematic knowledge of OBB processes (Johnston and Lewin, 1996; Webster and Wind, 1972). This knowledge requires a thorough understanding of the actual nature of organizational buying. Typically, several departments contribute to purchasing decisions, various organizational actors (OAs) are involved in the process, and multifarious objectives are pursued simultaneously (Johnston and Lewin, 1996). To mark a collection of organizational members who are involved in and influence the buying process, research developed the concept of the buying center (Webster and Wind, 1972); this continues to be the dominant notion in OBB theorizing (Wind and Thomas, 2010). Industrial marketers must have a good command of the buying center concept to ensure that their efforts are parsimoniously focused on pragmatic interactions with the powerful OAs and not on marginally influential members of the buying center (Garrido-Samaniego and Gutiérrez-Cillán, 2004). Therefore, researchers face an imperative need to advance our understanding of OBB outside of the traditional, industrialized markets. Defining the current priorities for OBB research, Wiersema (2013) emphasized that:

> While buying patterns are evolving greatly, our knowledge and models have not kept up with the dynamics of changing and emerging markets [. . .] We

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are in need of new insights and an up-to-date taxonomy as a foundation for future research and practice enhancement. (p. 488).

An important factor in understanding OBB beyond the traditional developed markets are the effects of national cultures on purchasing behavior. This particular influence, however, remains under-researched. For instance, Ćorić *et al.* (2017) summarized over 30 determinants influencing organizational buying process and purchasing decisions. Their list revealed that national culture, which systematically alters various aspects of human behavior (Hofstede *et al.*, 2010), has not fully received the empirical attention of OBB scholars.

The present research addresses the aforementioned issue and makes the following contributions. First, it answers the call of Wiersema (2013) to investigate purchasing behavior in new and emerging markets and casts light on the theorized link between national cultures and OBB. The study informs the practice of international B2B relationships by examining the ways in which the pattern of cultural characteristics found in the Arabian Gulf business environment shapes the decision-making processes of local organizational buyers.

Second, the study introduces the buying center configuration for a collectivistic and large-power distance (Hofstede *et al.*, 2010) business environment characterized by particularism (Hooker, 2003; Noer *et al.*, 2007) and pervaded by *wasta*, an informal influence practice indigenous to the Arab world (Berger *et al.*, 2015). In doing this, the study offers a rich understanding of in-house decision-making processes in a strategically important region of the Arabian Gulf.

Third, the present investigation uses a behavioral approach based on the assumption that purchasing decisions are made not by anthropomorphically abstracted procurement units but by specific individuals in specific circumstances. The behavioral approach overcomes the limitations of a rationalist perspective and the pseudo-causal models it engenders (Wilson, 2000); this study is the first, to the best of the author's knowledge, to apply the behavioral approach to research on OBB in the context of the Arabian Gulf.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. First, a literature review presents the theoretical background of OBB and the buying center research. Next, the methodology section explains the qualitative approach of the study, offers a description of the research setting and elaborates on the methods of data collection and analysis. The final section reports the results, which are followed by a discussion of the study's findings and implications.

2. Literature review

2.1 Theoretical background

OBB is an extensive research field that has been growing over decades with many influential studies advancing our understanding of this key component in business marketing (Reid and Plank, 2000). The foundations of OBB as a separate research discipline are found in the seminal work of Sheth, Webster and Wind and their colleagues (Robinson *et al.*, 1967; Sheth, 1973, 1996; Webster, 1965; Webster and Wind, 1972; Wind and Webster, 1972). Today, OBB continues stimulating prolific research output (Bachkirov *et al.*, 2016; Chavan *et al.*, 2018; Haensel and Hofmann, 2018; Mogre *et al.*, 2017; Kauffman, 1996; Lewin and Johnston, 1996; Liu and Chen, 2018; Mahapatra *et al.*, 2018; Madhavaram *et al.*, 2011; Wilson, 1996). Developing OBB models has become an established way of creating knowledge in the field, and a major review of foundational work (Johnston and Lewin, 1996) generated an overarching model of OBB that integrates previous conceptualizations.

The earlier models, although insightful into organizations' purchasing behavior, were linked to two acknowledged limitations: Western-centric theorizing (Lilien, 2016) and assumptions of rationality in OBB (Wilson, 2000). The first limitation is a corollary of the field's development dynamics: the earlier OBB models were built around the North American and Western European organizational structures (Lilien, 2016). It is an important limitation, because conceptualizations and frameworks rooted in the mature markets' processes may be inappropriate for application in emerging markets and, thus, lead to spurious findings (Sheth, 2011). Given that there is a clear reconfiguration of the industrial marketing focus from advanced economies towards developing markets (Wiersema, 2013), there is an urgent need for a concerted research effort to examine OBB processes in newer and emerging business environments. Current thinking in the field suggests that this can be achieved by examining whether and how industrial marketers establish appropriate relationships (Chicksand and Rehme, 2018) with the key decision-makers in the buying organizations (Järvi and Munnukka, 2009). This, however, can become an Achilles' heel in cross-cultural contexts. Specifically, in collectivistic and large-power-distance societies with convoluted communication hierarchies (Gudykunst *et al.*, 1996), the relationship between organizational actors (OAs) can mask the ultimate source of the purchase decision. Additionally, in Arab countries, the intra-organizational currents of decision-making influence can be further obfuscated by *wasta* – a social principle underlying information sharing, opportunity generation and power exertion in social networks (Berger *et al.*, 2015). Finally, the *wasta* processes occur against a background of a more general phenomenon of particularism, as opposite to universalism (Hooker, 2003). The particularists are guided in their judgments and decisions by the type of a relationship they have with others and by the specific nature of circumstances, which they view as unique. In contrast, the universalists emphasize uniform rules and expect everyone to follow these rules in all applicable situations. Thus, in the particularist environment of the Arabian Gulf (Noer *et al.*, 2007), the OAs' business judgments and decisions are determined by the nature of personal ties (or lack thereof), rather than by universal laws or standard company regulations. The latter, while important, are taken as mere guidelines and are only binding if enforced. All these national culture characteristics – collectivism, large power distance, particularism and the *wasta* tradition – can encumber the efforts of industrial marketers to build the relationships with appropriate people in the buying firm. Accordingly, how the national cultural characteristics of the Arabian Gulf shape OBB is one void in our knowledge that this study addresses.

The second limitation of the original OBB models is that they derived from normative approaches, which assume managerial rationality. Those models depicted organizational purchasing processes as a notional sequence of elements and factors presented in the form of a logical flow chart of boxes and

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arrows, ostensibly leading to a maximized outcome of a purchasing exercise. Such modeling, while meeting the assumptions of rationality, fails to capture the actual processes taking place (Wilson, 2000). To address this limitation, scholars turned to exploring process-driven organizational purchase management and OBB-related decision-making. An important finding was that OBB is a boundedly, not a completely rational process (Kemp *et al.*, 2018). Subsequent research (Turnbull *et al.*, 1996) marked an important shift in research focus from purchasing decision processes to decision-relevant relationships in 3OBB (Håkansson, 1982). The behavioral approach, however, has not yet been applied to the study of OBB in the Arabian Gulf, thus limiting our understanding of organizational purchasing dynamics in this region. This is the second knowledge gap that this study seeks to redress.

In sum, although earlier studies acknowledged the role of cultural dynamics in cross-cultural B2B contexts, this work is scant (Garrido-Samaniego and Gutiérrez-Cillán, 2004; Mintu-Wimsatt and Gassenheimer, 1996) and has not been updated for decades as far as the Arabian Gulf is concerned (Baker and Abu-Ismail, 1993). In addition, empirical behavioral research of OBB has not yet been extended into the new and emerging markets. These are two considerable limitations of the current OBB field because national cultures – in conjunction with economic, political, legal and technological aspects of the global environment – are a vital factor that differentially shapes organizational purchasing behavior across the borders. Given an important role that the progressive states of the Arabian Gulf play in the global economy, it is an urgent research task to update our understanding of the behavioral aspects of the organizational buying processes in this world region. Responding to this task, the present paper empirically addresses the above two knowledge gaps.

2.2 The buying center

This study uses the concept of the buying center, because of its key role in organizational buying processes (Johnston and Bonoma, 1981; Osmonbekov and Johnston, 2018), as a vehicle to better understand OBB in the Arabian Gulf. According to the foundational model of Webster and Wind (1972), the five core roles entail the following: *deciders* have the legitimate power to make a choice from the available options; *influencers* affect – directly or indirectly – the buying decisions by giving details on alternatives and their attributes; *buyers* hold both authority and responsibility for negotiating with the suppliers; *users* are those for whom an organizational purchase is intended; *gatekeepers* are in charge of the information flow and the purchasing department acts in the capacity of gatekeepers (Theng Lau *et al.*, 2003). Subsequently, Bonoma (1982/2006) and Dadzie *et al.* (1999) identified the role of *initiators*, who are the first to recognize the need for purchasing a product or service as a means to resolve the company's current issues.

From a behavioral perspective, all OAs are likely to have different expectations resulting from varied individual backgrounds, perceptual and judgmental distortions and dissimilar information sources (Sheth, 1973). This can create situations in which the buying center members have different vendor preferences (McNally, 2002). Another important behavioral aspect of the buying center is related to whether it should be conceptualized as a buying group or as a buying network. The buying group approach has received criticism on its appropriateness (Bristor, 1992); the current perspective is that of a buying network (Wind and Thomas, 2010).

A major development in the field was the introduction of an integrative framework of OBB (Johnston and Lewin, 1996), according to which the buying decisions of OAs in the buying center are impacted by several major influences and characteristics. The influences are: process/stages, buyer–seller relationships, conflict/negotiation tactics, communication networks, decision rules and stress; the characteristics are purchase, organizational, group, participant, seller, informational and environmental. All these powers have received thorough research attention (Reid and Plank, 2000), yet a sub-set of environmental influences stemming from the dynamics of national cultures has largely remained unexplored. The studies that did look into international differences in the buying centers did not link those differences to specific national cultural traits (Herbst *et al.*, 2008), which has created an incomplete picture of OBB in a globalized business environment. Specifically, although the traditional OA taxonomy (Webster and Wind, 1972) is aptly descriptive for the contexts in which it originated, that is, mature markets marked by individualism, low power distance (Hofstede *et al.*, 2010) and universalism (Hooker, 2003), it might be unable to capture accurately the configurations of the buying center in the world regions with a dissimilar cultural profile.

Given the national idiosyncrasies of the Arabian Middle East discussed in the methodology section, it is theorized that the buying center configuration in the Arabian Gulf may differ from those in traditional mature markets.

3. Methodology

The qualitative methodology was chosen because of the study's focus, that is, to gain a better understanding of OBB in an under-researched business environment. The new knowledge emerged from hermeneutic circles of coalescing data collection, data analysis, reflection and interpretation (Dubois and Gadde, 2002). The hermeneutic approach, which is qualitative interpretive in nature, highlights the importance of meanings that the study participants draw from their experiences. Eliciting such meanings and standpoints from the respondents was the methodological aim of this study. The hermeneutic approach was augmented by an empirical contextualization strategy (Ketokivi and Mantere, 2010), the purpose of which is to ensure the contextual authenticity of reasoning. It implies, in this study, that the research context, such as the characteristics of the national culture (collectivism, large power distance, particularism and *wasta*), are pertinent to the process of conceptualization.

3.1 Research contexts: the Arabian Gulf

The study was conducted in the Sultanate of Oman in the Arabian Gulf. The main reason for contextualizing this inquiry is that qualitative OBB investigations have not yet been done in this region of growing importance. Oman is a prosperous, oil-rich country that strategically fosters economic growth and development while sensitively protecting its culture and belief systems. This progressive nation is taken as a typical

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representative of the Arabian Gulf countries (Bachkirov, 2018) and has experienced intensive economic growth and accelerated urbanization in recent decades (Bachkirov and Shamsudin, 2017).

Regarding the region's cultural characteristics, Hofstede *et al.* (2010) argued that Arabic societies are collectivistic, high in uncertainty avoidance, high in power distance and moderate in masculinity/femininity. In organizations, collectivism leads to accentuated in-group cooperation, a salient psychological need for affiliation and a focus on the well-being and purposes of the in-group, rather than on the pursuit of personal goals. High uncertainty avoidance is associated with risk aversion, fear of failure, a strong need for harmony, conflict avoidance and views that the subordinate initiative must be restrained. Large power distance is evident in centralized and hierarchical decision-making, deference and submission to superiors and a general attitude of conformity and compliance. Managers in large-power-distance contexts, while avoiding direct guidance from their superiors, aim to anticipate their wishes and demands (Smith *et al.*, 2007). A moderate score on masculinity is linked to such values as benevolence, concern for the weak and the importance of interpersonal relationships. Empirical evidence provides support for Hofstede's theorizing. For example, Smith *et al.* (2007) demonstrated that Arab managers are highly reliant on formal rules, unwritten rules and on their co-workers, yet they tend to depend less on their own knowledge and experience or on their superiors. In terms of business models in the Arabian Gulf, these are primarily driven by relationships, not exchange (Rice, 1999). In sum, the current knowledge in international management suggests that the cultural properties of the research context are likely to play a role in shaping OBB and purchasing decision-making processes in the Arabian Gulf.

3.2 Data collection

Snowball sampling was used to recruit study participants. The starting point was the MBA students enrolled in an Organizational Behavior course at a large public university in the Arabian Gulf region. Next, each of them recruited work colleagues with reasonable organizational experience. All study participants worked at different job levels, ranging from operatives through supervisors and middle managers to top managers, and they occupied various positions in their companies. Their role in OBB included one or more of the following: making decisions in organizational purchases, advising on organizational purchases, being directly involved in the organizational buying process or being a direct user of a recent organizational purchase. Thus, all the study participants were "information rich" (Patton, 2002) and in a position to provide relevant and insightful qualitative data. A summary of study participant profiles is shown in Table I and detailed participant profiles are found in Table II.

The study participants were asked to evaluate organizational buying decision-making and purchasing process in their organizations. The evaluation entailed assessing the elements of the OBB model used by their organizations as well as the relationships between the elements. The total of 41 evaluations was returned as written reports, which were used to develop the buying center model for the Arabian Gulf.

Table I Participant profile: summary

Items	Frequency
Role in organizational buying:	
Makes decisions in organizational buying	11
Advises on organizational buying	30
Is a direct user of a recent organizational purchase	21
Note: Study participants typically had more than one role	
Job level	
Top manager	5
Middle manager	8
Supervisor	9
Operative	19
Years of professional experience	*M* (8.44)
	SD (5.12)
Gender	
Female	22
Male	19
Company size (number of employees)	*M* (2550)
	SD (5012)

Notes: Statistical abbreviations: *M* – sample mean; *SD* – standard deviation

3.3 Data analysis

English is the lingua franca in the Arabian Gulf's business community and is the medium of communication in local companies, which employ both local and expatriate workers and professionals. Therefore, the study participants were asked to write their reports in English. To preserve the authenticity of the participants' language, their errors (syntactical, grammatical, of appropriacy, etc.) were not edited. Through an iterative process, the author and two research assistants separately scrutinized the reports to identify any important observations related to OBB processes in the participants' organizations. The analysis entailed a continuous reflection on the data, their bearing on the study's focus and on the established perspectives in OBB. The data analysis process included a continuous self-challenging of one's own theoretical assumptions and questioning what empirically is assumed to be true.

The thick qualitative data generated from the participants' reports enabled the conceptualization of the buying center model for the Arabian Gulf. The model's characteristics emerged through the accrual, analysis and interpretation of the data. During the analysis, it was aimed to triangulate the essential characteristics of the emerging model to validate the analysis. There was an ongoing movement between the obtained data and published OBB research to ensure the rigor of the analysis. Thus, the proposed model, while being inductively constructed, is both grounded in empirical data and informed by existing theory. Exemplary excerpts from the reports were chosen to demonstrate the point for the key characteristics of the model.

4. Findings

The analysis of the data lead to a fuller understanding of the aspects related to the roles of influencers, deciders, buyers, users and the gatekeeping bureaucracy (the study adopts the term *gatekeeping bureaucracy* rather than *gatekeepers* because of

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Table II Participant profile

Ref.	Role in organizational buying	Position in the company	Industry	Job level	Years of prof. exp.	Gender	Company size (approximately employees)
01	Adviser user	Financial Analyst	Administration of Women's Counselling	O	3	Female	500
02	Adviser user	Information Security Specialist	Ministry of Religious Affairs	O	2	Male	2,000
03	Decider adviser user	Nursing Instructor	Medical Education	S	8	Female	120
04	User	Auditor	State Audit	O	4	Female	2,000
05	Adviser	Auditor	Mining	O	2	Male	1,000
06	Adviser	Auditor	Fishing	O	12	Male	2,000
07	User	Marketing Executive	Publishing and Advertising	O	3	Female	550
08	Adviser user	Head of Communication	Oil & Gas	MM	7	Male	450
09	Decider	Head of Purchasing Department	Publishing and Advertising	MM	9	Male	600
10	Adviser buyer	Senior Contracts Engineer	Oil & Gas	O	6	Female	7,500
11	Adviser buyer	Contract Analyst	Oil & Gas	O	4	Female	7,500
12	Adviser buyer	Contracts Officer	Public Sector	O	6	Male	500
13	Adviser user	Head of HRM Department	Public Sector	S	9	Male	100
14	Decider adviser	General Manager	Civil Engineering and Construction	TM	10	Female	24,000
15	Adviser user	Administrator	Higher Education	S	15	Male	50
16	User	Investment Analyst	Finance	O	3	Female	12
17	Decider adviser user	Deputy General Manager	Finance	TM	20	Male	12
18	Adviser user	Acting Branch Manager	Finance	MM	15	Female	50
19	Decider	Managing director	Retail	TM	10	Male	300
20	Adviser	LPO officer	Retail	O	7	Female	300
21	Adviser	Purchasing committee member	Healthcare	MM	15	Male	600
22	Adviser	Purchase officer	Services	O	5	Female	500
23	User	Accountant	Services	O	6	Female	500
24	Adviser user	Senior Project Manager and Member of the Procurement Committee	Wastewater industry (projects and operations)	MM	15	Male	800
25	Adviser	Senior buyer	Wastewater industry (services)	S	10	Female	700
26	Adviser	Purchase officer	Pharmaceutical	O	4	Female	20
27	Adviser	Supply Chain Analyst	Oil and Gas	S	15	Male	1,900
28	Decider adviser	General Manager	Finance	TM	16	Male	1,400
29	Decider adviser user	Head of Department	Finance	MM	6	Male	1,400
30	Buyer	Buyer	Oil and Gas	O	3	Female	1,600
31	Decider	CEO	Telecom	TM	17	Female	1,000
32	User	Accountant	Oil and Gas	O	3	Female	8,000
33	Adviser	Procurement Specialist	Oil and Gas	O	3	Female	7,700
34	Adviser	Account Relationship Manager	Banking	O	3	Female	200
35	User	Head of Department	Public Sector	S	5	Male	4,000
36	Adviser	Head of Department	Higher Education	S	15	Female	100
37	User	Senior Geophysicist	Oil and Gas	MM	13	Male	500
38	User	Finance officer	Investments	O	2	Male	50
39	Decider adviser user	Head of Information Technology	Investments	MM	15	Male	50
40	Decider adviser user	Acting Catering Officer	Health service (hospital)	S	11	Female	4,000
41	Decider adviser user	Catering Supervisor	Public Sector	S	9	Female	20,000

Notes: Key and abbreviations: Ref. – participant reference; Decider – makes decisions in organizational buying; Adviser – advises on organizational buying; User – is a direct user of a recent organizational purchase; Buyer – is directly involved in organizational buying process; TM – top manager; MM – middle manager; S – supervisor; O – operative; prof. exp. – professional experience; and LPO – local purchase order

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the content of this role in the research context). In addition, the data analysis allowed to identify and define the role of advisers and revealed the interplay between rules and relationships in purchasing processes.

4.1 Influencers

The data revealed several types of influencers. The first two types are those who directly and/or indirectly provide information on alternatives and criteria (Webster and Wind, 1972) and those who are powerful internal or external stakeholders in a position to influence purchasing decisions by virtue of various factors. The following comment exemplifies the first type:

> The organizational purchasing decisions making is done by operation manager in the head office [. . .] The operation manager get the advice from planning department since the planning department have full database of fish required and types of the fish the company should purchase. Also, the finance department play as a main influencer for the decision; they prepare a yearly budget for fish purchase. [Ref.06]

The second type of influencers is illustrated by this observation:

> Influencers are the internal and external stakeholders of the company i.e. internal stakeholders (owners and investors) and the external stakeholders (customers, suppliers, creditors, and the government). [Ref.16]

The data also showed that the local community may act as an important stakeholder-influencer (cf. Sheth, 2011):

> The community where the company has operations in the interior can have influence on company's decisions because the company has obligations to satisfy them [community members] so [that] the operations can run safely without interruptions. [Ref.10]

Influence can originate not only from OAs but also from contextual dimensions:

> Influence is considered as any factor that effects the decision makers, including government policies, company policies, stakeholders, cost cutting. [Ref.32]

The study participants noted a potentially negative effect that influencers can exert on a purchasing process if/when they pull deciders in differing directions and, thus, delay the decision:

> The General Manager is the decider [. . .] The decision could be affected by the influencers who will look to the purpose of purchasing from different points of views. For example, the head of purchasing unit will prefer to approve the quotation of the supplier who has a long term relation with the establishment even if their price is a little bit more than others'. On the other hand, the director of print department will focus on the quality of the item as they will be the end-users and their work will relay on it. However, in the finance and auditing department will focus and try to influence the decider to choose the less expensive item as they mostly care about the budget. [Ref.07]

The findings showed that the government can effectively act as influencers (Sheth, 2011). The type of sector – private versus public – may be a factor. In heavily regulated governmental organizations, people may subjectively perceive an absence of influencers, while in actuality, this role is enacted by governmental authorities:

> As the establishment is a government entity, there are no direct internal or external influencers on the purchasing decisions. In addition, the whole buying process is very systematic and the communication runs according to a specific instructions. [Ref.09]

4.2 Advisers

Deciders receive both informal inputs from influencers and formal inputs from advisers in large organizations with complex decision-making processes. The difference between the two is based on the (non)involvement of gatekeeping bureaucracy in purchasing decision interactions. The interactions between influencers and deciders flow smoothly and are unobstructed by gatekeeping bureaucracy. The interactional process between advisers and deciders, in contrast, has to go through bureaucratic barriers. In a report by an information security specialist, the computer technicians were identified as advisers, while the information security specialist and the finance department were identified as influencers:

> The computer technicians, first, identify the need to acquire new computers. They have to communicate this need through formal letter to the head of the information technology and the head of networks. These two managers are in charge to decide whether to buy, what to buy, where to buy, and how to buy. The process of informing the managers about the needs may take time because of the bureaucratic and gatekeepers that impede the flow of information [. . .]. The deciders are influenced by the information security specialists and the finance department. They exchange information smoothly and decide the most appropriate computers that fit with the nature of the work. [Ref.02]

4.3 Users

The findings suggested two categories of users: willing users and reluctant (unwilling) users. The former know that the purchase will be suitable for their job or project and appropriate for their skill level. Reluctant users, in contrast, doubt the appropriateness of the purchase. Such perception can be induced by circumstances in which the reasons for a purchase are not the operational requirements but an unrelated motivation; for example, a purchase deal is a result of pressures by dominant stakeholders or an exercise in relationship maintenance. It emerged that users' orientation, that is, willing or reluctant, may depend on the nature of their organizational roles. One participant reported that: "*Willing users [. . .] are employees working within the administration. On the other hand, the unwilling users are the field workers*". [Ref.01]

An important observation was that the input received from reluctant users must be treated with caution:

> The unwilling users cannot be a good communication element in this process because they cannot give appropriate opinion on such organizational buying decision and may transfer ambiguous feedback. [Ref.01]

Depending on the nature of the business, users may or may not be able to communicate directly with deciders. This study revealed an additional reason: when a specialized knowledge is required, an intermediary link is established, for example, technicians:

> Information flows from the deciders to the technicians and they in turn pass on the information to the users. [. . .] The users' feedback or suggestions regarding the planned purchase are transmitted to the technicians with no communication barriers [. . .] If the users want to change their computer types they have to write a formal letter mentioning significant reasons for their requests and send it through technicians to the deciders. After studying the reasons, decider will take an action whether to change or not. [Ref.02]

Alternatively, users communicate directly with the purchasing unit rather than with deciders:

> Users communicate with purchasing unit about their need, which, in turn, contact the deciders to obtain approvals. [Ref.10]

The latter pattern is likely to exist in organizations, in which end users have a high status because of their role:

> The end users are those who define the overall organization's demand and as they are responsible for delivering the job in the organization, it's their responsibility to define the job needed to be done to achieve the objectives, not only defining what needs to be done but also why, how and when; so if we talk about procurement in specific, they will be in a better position to

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define the procurements required for a specific year in order for them to deliver. [Ref.33]

Expanding the categorization of users, the data revealed two additional types: direct users and indirect users or sub-users. The latter are units subordinate to direct users and have a limited role in the organizational buying process:

The direct users not only receive the decisions, they can also interact, negotiate and [give] feedback in order to had effective decisions that meet overall goals. And the sub-units, that come under the main users, are indirectly related to the deciders and don't give feedback [on decisions]. [Ref.34]

4.4 Gatekeeping bureaucracy

The data demonstrated contrasting views on the gatekeeping bureaucracy in the organizational buying process. Users tend to perceive bureaucratic barriers negatively: "*Bureaucracy plays a major* role *in the process which in fact causes unwanted hassle.*" [Ref.35]. Top management, however, discerns advantages of having bureaucratic barriers in place:

This model offers a strong barrier for the organization and this barrier ensures strong control on hand of senior management. [Ref.14]

Bureaucratic barriers can be perceived positively because:

[...] if you, as a user, want to break the barrier, you must convince the people who represent this barrier by using the following methods: (1) competitive cost; (2) easily, readily, and globally available; (3) approved by major organizations and government organizations according to the specification and quality; (4) unique product. [Ref.14]

Large organizations for which safeguarding standards are important may have multidimensional bureaucratic structures:

This organization has relatively high assurance standards. Therefore, the bureaucracy comes at two intersections. [The first] is between the purchase unit and the decision makers in order to maintain transparency and to have clear documented guidelines and submissions. The bureaucracy also appears between the purchase units and the units (end users). The demand or the requests from the units are submitted along with the approval from the individual unit's line managers. This is to maintain accountability and for assurance purposes, making sure the managers are aware of the requests raised by his/her team to avoid duplication. [Ref.32]

4.5 Rules and relationships: Buyers

The data captured the principle of pliability of rules for organizational purchasing. An industrial company, for example, may have an established process: the board of directors and the general manger formally approve a purchase; the approval is forwarded to the operations manager, who tasks the purchasing department; the latter selects the best vendors and effectuates the purchase. Yet this process enjoys certain flexibility:

Not all the time the purchasing department follows this procedure; sometimes they broken the rules by make the order based on unapproved request from top management. And sometimes they do not double-check the budget from finance department. [Ref.06]

Similarly, a supervisor in a large hospital confirmed that:

[...] the official structures not applied in daily practices, where the contribution of unofficial aspects occurs to meet the organizational purposes [...]. Many written communications tend to ignore many hierarchal managers in order to reduce time constrain and get things done faster. In other words, purchasing communication flows has been changed in the firm unofficially. [Ref.40]

An intricate structure of the relationship between the OAs involved in the buying process can mask the ultimate source of the decision to purchase. The following comment illustrates the point:

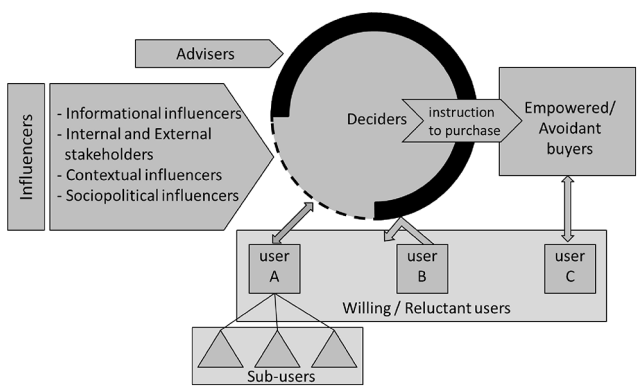
The official authority for all furnace purchasing is the general manager, the purchase committee and the finance manager. The influencer of the decision is the outside consulter hired by the company in the period they want to purchase the furnaces as well as the operator of these furnaces. [...] However the decider of purchasing are the maintenance department and the mining department. Both of them work together to decide whether there is need for the purchase [...] Before they make a decision they sent a request to the general manager to get the advice from such consultation parties who have experience in furnaces manufacturing industry. When the consultant give a clear feedback whether the company require to buy a new furnace or to maintain the available one, the mining department sent a request to the purchasing department. Then purchasing department play a role of [em] powered buyer. [Ref.05]

While identifying the initiator role – the maintenance department and the mining department – this excerpt illustrates a convoluted decisional structure that puts particular pressure on buyers. From the above comment, it is evident that buyers can feel empowered: in addition to official authority and formal responsibility for negotiating with suppliers they enjoy the support of deciders and/or influencers in their buying role. Some buyers, however, take an avoidant stance. One senior buyer elaborated on the factors prompting avoidance predispositions and stressed that they use: "*avoidant buyer* [approach] *due to some facts like government bureaucracy*, [requirements to] *follow purchasing policies and procedures, budget influence [...] all that effect in decision making.*" [Ref.25].

4.6 The buying center model for the Arabian Gulf

The findings suggested the buying center model (Figure 1) that is grounded in empirical data obtained from organizations in the Arabian Gulf and aimed at describing OBB in emerging markets with socio-political governance (Sheth, 2011). As the figure illustrates, before deciding on an organizational purchase, deciders receive an input from influencers and advisers. Four types of influencers are captured by the model. First, informational influencers are those OAs who provide information on a purchase's alternatives and their attributes (Webster and Wind, 1972). Second, internal and external stakeholders are those whose influence is derived from various relational factors stemming from the collectivistic nature of the business environment. Third, the organizational context (policies, operational needs, etc.) is conceptualized as a symbolic OA and is denoted as contextual influencers. Finally,

Figure 1 The buying center model for emerging markets with socio-political governance



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socio-political influencers include government, religious institutions and local communities (Sheth, 2011). The pointer of the influencer cluster is located opposite a dashed circumference line that demarcates deciders. The dashed line suggests an unrestricted interaction between influencers and deciders whereby influencers provide their input at will without going through gatekeeping bureaucratic barriers depicted as an incomplete thick black circumference line around the decider area. Such an interaction mode, however, is not available to advisers. The role of advisers, although somewhat similar to influencers, is to provide formal rather than informal inputs into purchasing decisions, which does require crossing the gatekeeping bureaucracy.

The model details the ways in which willing and reluctant users may engage in organizational purchasing decisions. The interactions of User "A" illustrate a scenario in which, because of the nature of an organization's business model, users and deciders can interact unhindered with each other; this concept is represented by a two-directional arrow linking User "A" and the dashed section of the deciders' symbol. User "A" is also connected to a set of sub-users who report to direct users and do not participate in purchasing decision-making. Sub-users are shown for User "A" for illustrative purposes only; any other user can have a set of sub-users. The second scenario depicts User "B" interactions. Here, the attempts of User "B" to make suggestions about a planned purchase encounter a barrier of the gatekeeping bureaucracy; this can lead to a frustrated interaction attempt, shown here by a broken arrow. The third scenario involves User "C", who directly interacts with buyers, rather than with deciders. This situation can arise when users have a high-level status in their organization and are the key OAs in determining the company's performance.

Finally, a common shade for the components of the model symbolizes the presence of a unifying, underlying dimension of particularism (Noer *et al.*, 2007).

5. Discussion

In view of the field's shifting from transaction- to relations-focused approaches and transitioning from domestic to global sourcing processes, Sheth (1996) emphasized the need for OBB scholars "to learn new concepts, methods and theories appropriate for the new world of OBB" (p. 12). The differences in cross-cultural values that are critical to OBB have emerged as a dynamic demanding urgent scholarly attention. Responding to the call of Wiersema (2013), this study uses empirical behavioral data to update our understanding of OBB in the Arabian Gulf.

5.1 National cultural influences on OBB

The reported findings and the proposed model contribute to our better understanding of the organizational buying decision processes beyond the established, mature markets. A comparative table (Table III) summarizes the similarities and differences in the buying center configuration in the traditional mature industrial markets and the emerging markets with socio-political governance. To achieve a comprehensive insight into OBB in the Arabian Gulf, both etic and emic perspectives were applied. The etic paradigm describes behavioral phenomena using criteria and notions external to a researched culture. In contrast, the emic approach describes behaviors identified in a particular culture by using the concepts originated in that culture without imposing external conceptualizations.

Table III The buying center configurations: a comparison

Traditional mature markets	Markets with socio-political governance (the Arabian Gulf)
Initiators	Initiators
Influencers	Informational influencers
	External stakeholders
	Contextual influencers
	Socio-political influencers
Not identified	Advisers
Deciders	Deciders
Buyers	Empowered buyers
	Avoidant buyers
Users	Willing user
	Unwilling users
	Sub-users
Gatekeepers	Gatekeeping bureaucracy
Not identified	Particularism as an underlying environment

5.1.1 OBB in the Arabian Gulf: an etic perspective

From the etic standpoint, the current thinking in the field of international management (Hofstede *et al.*, 2010) suggests that the two cultural dimensions – collectivism and large power distance – can be factors in the profile of OAs and their buying center interactions. Collectivism promotes a clear distinction between the in-groups and out-groups that is a fundamental and integral part of people's construction of social reality in collectivistic cultures. Large power distance is linked to resources being available only to a few at the top of hierarchies and information being localized and hoarded.

Collectivism and large power distance are theorized to shape the profiles of deciders and influencers in the Arabian Gulf. The former exercise their power by endorsing, modifying, or cancelling the buyer's tentative decisions. Prior to choosing a particular action, though, deciders obtain the influencers' perspectives, as their power stems from their membership in professional, personal, or hereditary networks and hierarchical structures. Influencing forces also come from government, religion, and local communities, which is in agreement with a recent proposition that emerging markets tend to be governed by socio-political institutions rather than competition (Sheth, 2011).

From the collectivist perspective, organizational buyers who belong to an in-group comprising deciders and influencers acquire an empowered buyer status. Buyers who are outside of such an in-group perceive themselves, in contrast, as disempowered and act the role of avoidant buyers, which would involve trying to evade answerability for purchasing. Such behavioral intentions and actions of avoidant buyers can also be interpreted within the power distance dimension. Hierarchically divided employees in large-power-distance environments view each other as existentially unequal in power. Within these mutually shared perceptions, the subordinates expect the boss to be a "good and benevolent father". Should this expectation be unmet, the superior's authority is ideologically rejected. If the "bad" superior abuses power, however, the subordinates who become victims are unlikely to attempt to rectify the situation and would passively accept their

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plight. If a purchasing decision goes wrong and things turn out differently than anticipated, disempowered buyers would try to avoid answerability to evade such predicament.

The notion of large power distance also explains the appropriateness of classifying users into willing and reluctant. Willing users understand the reasons behind an organizational purchase and are clear about how this will benefit their performance. Reluctant users, in contrast, are not convinced of the purchase's suitability for their operational needs. Due to large power distance, however, reluctant users do not engage in discussions on purchase appropriateness but display psychological resistance once the purchase has been made.

Large power distance strengthens the role of the gatekeeping bureaucracy – a hierarchical structure whose purpose is to serve the top executives' need for managerial control. Such positioning makes the role of the gatekeeping bureaucracy qualitatively distinct from the role of gatekeepers in the developed markets. There, the purchasing department obtains information from the external sources, pre-screens it and decides whether and how to disseminate the pre-selected content to which members of the buying center (Theng Lau *et al.*, 2003); the strategic aim is to regulate customer relationships. The gatekeeping bureaucracy's role in the emerging markets of the Arabian Middle East is determined by socio-political, faith-based governance of organizations (Sheth, 2011); the strategic aim here is to regulate the relationships with institutions and their leaders and to enhance managerial control.

5.1.2 OBB in the Arabian Gulf: an emic view

To further evaluate the proposed model, it was examined through an emic lens. Recall that the current view is that the buying center constitutes a buying network (Wind and Thomas, 2010), rather than a buying group (Reid and Plank, 2000). Recent research showed that the conceptualization of business networking is influenced by national cultures (Ivanova-Gongne and Torkkeli, 2018). The networking force and a major emic phenomenon that permeates Arab culture in the Middle East is *wasta* ("going in between"), a process that people use to achieve their goals via connections with key individuals. As a social capital process (Burt, 1997), w*asta* is a distinctive phenomenon although other cultures developed comparable modes of informal influence, for example, guanxi, jeitinho, blat (Michailova and Worm, 2003; Smith *et al.*, 2012) through strong and weak ties in high- and low-density networks (Granovetter, 1983). *Wasta's* origins come from low-trust environments where people are hesitant to delegate key business decisions to the out-groups; the primary concern here is to reinforce family control and ownership rather than effectiveness (Sidani and Thornberry, 2013). *Wasta* is conceptualized as a three-dimensional construct (Berger *et al.*, 2015). *Mojamala*, the affective component, denotes a socio-emotional bond rooted in the sense of loyalty, harmony and trust. *Hamola*, the volitional element, comprises empathetic benevolence, mutual reciprocity and unreserved duty to help when asked. Finally, *somah* is the cognitive aspect that defines the extent of the reciprocal credence in a business relationship and predictability of a partner's future actions.

Although initially *wasta* mainly served the interests of the family and tribe, it has additionally become a tool in modern Arab societies for intercessions with the government and in business transactions (Berger *et al.*, 2015). *Wasta's* effects on the latter have not been conclusively established. Some argue that this practice is destructive of corporate performance (Sidani and Thornberry, 2013), but others advocate the benefits of a *wasta* network in business (AL-Husan *et al.*, 2015). *Wasta's* advantages as a type of organizational politics arguably include access to business opportunities, risks and costs minimization, access to decision-makers, acquisition of private and confidential information and intellectual capital and generation of trust (AL-Husan *et al.*, 2015). The latter is particularly important because of the relational benefits it provides (Chou and Chen, 2018; Dadzie *et al.*, 2018; Youssef *et al.*, 2018).

Wasta's ubiquitous presence in the Arabian Middle East and the dual nature of its organizational consequences both brings together OAs in the buying center and introduces tensions between them. Influencers may pursue dissimilar, if not opposite, goals when interacting with deciders. Whose influence prevails may be determined by the strength of individual influencers' *wasta* links. Similarly, the support of a *wasta* network encourages buyers in their proactivity and stimulates them to adopt an empowered buyer's role. Buyers outside of *wasta* networks, in contrast, are unlikely to be able to minimize the risks of a poor course of action and, thus, intuitively prefer an avoidant buyer's role.

To sum up, both etic and emic interpretations of the findings suggest that OBB in the Arabian Gulf, as elsewhere, is a boundedly rational process, in which intuition and political behavior play a definitive role in organizational purchasing processes (Wilson, 2000).

5.2 Implications, limitations, future directions

5.2.1 Theoretical implications

This study's findings are valuable for both theorists and practitioners. Based on the fine-grained analysis of 41 evaluative reports generated by deciders, advisers and users of organizational purchases, the study provides several substantive theoretical contributions to the field of international OBB. The first theoretical contribution lies in answering the call of Wiersema (2013) for examining OBB in new and emerging markets and elucidating the possible links of purchasing behavior with the etic cultural dimensions of collectivism and large power distance and with the emic phenomenon of *wasta* in the Arabian Gulf. Access to in-group membership (collectivism) and *wasta* networks may explain the dynamics between the deciders and influencers and whether the buyer is empowered or avoidant; large power distance is likely to play a role in the shaping willing/reluctant stance of users and strengthening the status of the gatekeeping bureaucracy.

The second theoretical contribution consists in advancing our understanding of OBB from an international perspective and developing the buying center model for the Arabian Gulf. The study reveals the typology of decisional influencers, introduces and defines the role of advisers and differentiates it from the role influencers, clarifies the role of the gatekeeping bureaucracy and differing perceptions thereof by OAs. It empirically validates the theoretical proposition that a reconceptualization of the buying center's OAs is required for emerging markets with socio-political governance (Sheth, 2011) found in collectivistic and large-power-distance cultures (Hofstede *et al.*, 2010) and associated with particularism (Hooker, 2003; Noer *et al.*, 2007).

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The third theoretical contribution is that the buying center model for the Arabian Gulf is based on the descriptive behavioral data directly obtained from OAs involved in the organizational purchasing process. This approach draws understanding of OBB from reports describing OAs' actual behaviors and is not restrained by the drawbacks of rationalist theorizing about speculative causal relationships (Wilson, 2000).

5.2.2 Managerial implications

The theoretical contributions of the study define its managerial relevance. The paper addresses the pressing need of industrial marketers for new, enriched and hands-on understanding of the emerging markets' unfamiliar environments (Wiersema, 2013) and contributes to reducing the theory/practice gap in business-to-business marketing (Gummesson, 2014). The overall practical value of the findings lies in the richness of new knowledge about how cultural idiosyncrasies of the business environment in the Arabian Gulf shape the purchasing behavior of organizational buyers. It provides the practitioners – international industrial marketers – with insights that organizational buyers in the Arabian Gulf are likely to retain their decision-making patterns when dealing with international vendors. This is a particular case of a general notion that in cross-cultural business interactions, economic actors replicate their social order, that is, culture (Haugland, 1998).

The distinctive managerial implications of the study are, first, that the industrial marketers from individualistic and low-power-distance societies – for example, the Anglo world – should not regard their business-to-business selling proficiency acquired in home country as a guarantee of efficacious results in a culturally distant setting of the Arabian Gulf. Discerning the power relationships and decision-making dynamics in the buying center is already challenging because of organizational politics and influence processes (Johnston and Bonoma, 1981). In the Arabian Gulf, the collectivistic and large-power-distance environments, coupled with a *wasta* networking tradition, present additional challenges for accurate identification of the actual decision maker (s) in the buying firm. The opaque nature of decisional dynamics, a convoluted structure of communication patterns and interactions between the OAs of the buying center, all of whom are likely to have competing vendor preferences (McNally, 2002), are liable to obfuscate who propels the organizational purchasing action. A vital requirement for business-to-business industrial marketing success in the Arabian Gulf is, thus, an extensive and conclusive knowledge of how collectivistic and large-power-distance values, embedded in *wasta* practice, influence OBB.

The second managerial implication is that international industrial marketers may have to reframe their conception of how purchasing decisions are likely to be made in the Arabian Gulf. The study revealed that, in addition to collectivism and large-power-distance, cultural particularism needs to be considered when approaching organizational buyers. Rather than anticipating a set of universal principles to govern business processes, industrial marketers may want to embrace the particularist nature of the Arabian Gulf business community.

The third managerial implication stems from the empirical confirmation of the conjecture that the buying center can expand beyond the firm (Wind and Thomas, 2010). Extending those authors' theoretical proposition that the buying center can incorporate outside partner organizations, this study has demonstrated that external stakeholders (e.g. the governmental regulatory bodies and the communities) can have a role in the buying center. This agrees with the recent theorizing (Sheth, 2011) that the Arabian Gulf's emerging markets are governed by socio-political and faith-based forcers, that is, the government, religion and the local community. From the practical vantage point, these influences, too, should be regarded by international vendors pursuing superior industrial marketing outcomes in this region.

The final managerial implication is that when applying the proposed model in markets with socio-political governance, industrial marketers should consider that the role of the gatekeeping bureaucracy in organizational purchasing decision processes generates mixed perceptions from OAs. On the one hand, historical legacies in the Arabian Gulf region (Baker and Abu-Ismail, 1993), where "the stamp of approval" remains an inalienable part of organizational processes (Rice, 2003), can explain positive views of bureaucracy. On the other hand, the dynamic changes in organizational cultures brought about by globalization trigger critical attitudes to the gatekeeping bureaucracy. It is within this ambiguous context that industrial marketers should correctly identify the stance of the ultimate decision-maker and act accordingly.

5.3 Limitations and future directions

The limitations of the study suggest future research avenues. The data were obtained only from one culturally specific world region. Extending the line of reasoning that national cultures are a significant force exerting profound influences on OBB, future research should aim to investigate organizational purchasing decision processes beyond the Anglo world and the Arabian Middle East to include other cultural clusters, for example, Nordic Europe, Germanic Europe, Eastern Europe, Latin Europe, Latin America, Southern Asia and Confucian Asia (Gupta *et al.*, 2002). This may necessitate revisiting the OAs' taxonomy and re-examining the content of the roles of those involved in organizational buying. Additionally, while validating the presented model of the buying center for different cultural environments could be one option, an alternative strategy would entail conducting exploratory studies guided by grounded theory to understand the complex array of factors that influence OBB internationally. Future studies should also look into how to synthesize different culturally determined patterns of OBB to create an overarching global model of the buying center.

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